

My tech resolutions



Jayesh Shinde
Technical Editor –
Test Centre
jayesh.shinde@digit.in

"There's a very fine line between essential (tech) and addiction and we should all learn to recognise it."

Before I started writing this month's column, I was reminded of my column from exactly a year ago. Back then I cribbed about how technology overload can throw your life off balance, if you aren't careful, and my (then future) endeavour to curtail technology's irritating influence through 2015. To that effect, I'm happy to report that I have successfully exorcised some of my technology demons. This year has been a satisfying effort in my quest to drag myself out of a tech-triggered quagmire. Apart from keeping my phone turned off on weekends, it's always been on silent mode (with notifications for everything except emails switched off) and this has helped me not feel constantly connected to my phone – definitely no phantom phone calls anymore, woot! I have also greatly reduced my social media minutes, freeing up precious hours spent on other productive ventures (more reading time, for instance). While tuning into music off my phone, I make sure I put it on airplane mode if I don't want to be distracted. Little things.

Enriching experience this endeavour has been, I must say. While doing all this, I also realized something important. It's not as much to do with multitasking but immersion. I can multitask when required but I was trying to be less distracted by technology. Just like when you're gaming you don't want your PC's antivirus to keep popping up and when you're watching a movie you yell at commercial breaks, similarly I was conditioning myself to not be distracted by digital, social, and online triggers. I want to be able to look aimlessly out of the train window or spend some quality time with my friends and family away from the Internet and my smartphone.

You, too, should give this a try, if you haven't already. Technology is an integral part of our life, no doubt, it would be foolish to suggest anything but. However, don't let its triggers negatively disrupt the balance you're trying to strike. There's a very fine line between essential (tech) and addiction and we should all learn to recognise it.

Onwards to my list of resolutions for 2016. I'm not trying to shoot for the moon, instead focusing on making one or two tiny changes in my life – with the help of technology, of course.

Needless to say, the climate change debate has been of personal interest to me – last month India and the World vowed to fight global

warming with renewed vigour. After experiencing a sweltering summer from February through November of last year, I'm going to try and make a difference to minimize my energy impact going forward this year. Saving the planet is crucial to our existence and once again technology will come to our rescue, if only we decide to be a little more open-minded and concerned about our impact on the world. After seeing a solar power bank that works, innovative (power-saving) lighting solution, and realizing the potential of DIY hacks to automate and conserve power around the house, I am confident of endorsing an eco-sensitive tech-powered lifestyle in 2016. Fingers crossed.

Can technology be good for your health? Of course! As much as I rant about distancing yourself from technology's ill effects, I have come to realize that embracing helpful technology gadgets can lead to a positive lifestyle. I've been using several fitness bands over the past two-three months, and I've seen how it's acutely made me aware of my physical activity levels, or lack thereof. This year, I am going to ensure I sleep better and move more thanks to fitness trackers for positive self-reinforcement. At the end of a hectic day, it's good to see that you've walked so many steps, or when you wake up in the morning, it's insightful to analyze your sleep cycle. Anything that helps you stay motivated, help you achieve your fitness goals is worthy of embracing into your life. I'm also going to take a deeper dive into mobile gaming this coming year – probably invest in a phone controller, too. Not that I'm tired of gaming on my PS4, I don't want to miss out on the best of mobile gaming this year. Hey, blowing off steam through technology is important, too!

Enabling you to do everything better is essentially what technology strives to do. And when you practice self-restraint, it enriches your life even more. Or at least that's what I've experienced. Embrace technology wherever necessary and leave it be where it isn't. At least that's my mantra for 2016. What's yours? 

Let me know your thoughts on this column at: facebook.com/jayesh.shinde
| [@jshinde](https://twitter.com/jshinde) | jayesh.shinde@digit.in